

Among executive officials, the President of the United States is absolutely immune from damages liability arising from official acts. *Nixon v. Fitzgerald*, 457 U. S. 731 (1982). This immunity, however, is based on the President's "unique position in the constitutional scheme," *id.*, at 749, and it does not extend indiscriminately to the President's personal aides, see *Harlow, supra*, or to Cabinet level officers, *Mitchell v. Forsyth*, 472 U. S. 511 (1985). Nor are the highest executive officials in the States protected by absolute immunity under federal law. See *Scheuer v. Rhodes, supra*.

III

As a class, judges have long enjoyed a comparatively sweeping form of immunity, though one not perfectly well defined. Judicial immunity apparently originated, in medieval times, as a device for discouraging collateral attacks and thereby helping to establish appellate procedures as the standard system for correcting judicial error. See Block, *Stump v. Sparkman* and the History of Judicial Immunity, 1980 Duke L. J. 879. More recently, this Court found that judicial immunity was "the settled doctrine of the English courts for many centuries, and has never been denied, that we are aware of, in the courts of this country." *Bradley v. Fisher*, 13 Wall. 335, 347 (1872). Besides protecting the finality of judgments or discouraging inappropriate collateral attacks, the *Bradley* Court concluded, judicial immunity also protected judicial independence by insulating judges from vexatious actions prosecuted by disgruntled litigants. *Id.*, at 348.

In the years since *Bradley* was decided, this Court has not been quick to find that federal legislation was meant to diminish the traditional common-law protections extended to the judicial process. See, e. g., *Pierson v. Ray*, 386 U. S. 547 (1967). On the contrary, these protections have been held to extend to Executive Branch officials who perform quasi-judicial functions, see *Butz v. Economou, supra*, at 513-514,